while Ankita, without making it either to the merit list and waiting list, had got a job. Soon, a revised waiting list showed Ankita at the top.

Following a massive furore, over 2,000 petitioners moved court, seeking a review of candidates appointed on recommendations by a panel formed by Chatterjee in November 2019 to "guide, supervise and dictate" the SSC on appointments. The committee, comprising close aides of Chatterjee, violated the SSC Act, and allegedly pushed undeserving candidates. A judicial enquiry committee—the Justice Ranjit Bag Committee—constituted by the HC had unearthed anomalies like the use of the RTI Act to procure answer sheets of undeserving candidates for increasing marks, destroying OMR (Optimal Mark Recognition) sheets and issuing fake appointment letters. Such irregularities were carried out by panel members themselves, as repeated interrogation revealed. Shanti Prasad Sinha, the panel head, reportedly confessed during grilling that he had acted as per instructions of top authorities. All the time, it was becoming apparent that huge amounts of money were exchanged in lieu of appointments. Allegations arose from all corners about candidates having had to pay bribes of Rs 8-18 lakh to political touts. More complaints poured in and Ramesh Malik, who had been seeking a job as a primary school teacher, filed a petition in the Calcutta High Court, drawing the attention of the judiciary to 10 alleged illegal appointments favouring the family of Biswambhar Mondal, Chatterjee's bodyguard.

The HC has so far terminated the services of 265 primary teachers who allegedly bought jobs by submitting blank answer sheets. Some of those in the business of ensuring jobs had allegedly entered into an arrangement with the candidates whereby they would submit blank answer sheets—a code that would help identify those who were to be empanelled. "The number of primary teachers recruited through such irregular means will ultimately cross 15,000," claims lawyer Firdous Shamim.

As dramatic footage of money stacked up like a pyramid was broadcast, Union ministers Dharmendra Pradhan and Jyotiraditya Scindia, who were in town for a BJP programme, used the opportunity to dub the ruling Trinamool as a party "steeped in corruption, from top to bottom". Pradhan insisted on meeting protesting candidates, who claim they were unfairly deprived of teaching jobs because of the scam, and said he would seek a reply from Mamata Banerjee on the issue. The Congress and the Left too joined in, demanding the government's dissolution, as it had "lost the credibility and ethics to govern".

HOW TMC IS TACKLING THE BLOW

Though Mamata had breezily dismissed the scam on July 21 by saying that errors are natural in any big undertaking, the arrest of her top minister in a shower of allegedly ill-begotten wealth has shaken her. This prompted Mamata's nephew and party general secretary, Abhishek Banerjee, to step in. Abhishek, it is known, was in favour of making Chatterjee pay for his alleged role in the scam right away. But some senior leaders are said to have reasoned with Mamata that it would be too risky to leave Chatterjee to his fate. Already, Chatterjee has told the media that his SoS call to the party chief had gone unanswered. In fact, on his arrest memo, Chatterjee has allegedly put in Mamata's name and phone number as his nearest relative in case of any emergency. This has caused consternation and Mamata, according to sources, is livid with Chatterjee for leaking her personal number to the ED.

In 2016, too, Abhishek was strongly against having Narada scam-accused leaders in the cabinet. Early in 2022, he again sought the axing of tainted leaders. But those veteran leaders, many of them Mamata loyalists, made it look like young leaders in Trinamool were growing impatient for a generational shift that would bode ill for the party. Mamata was persuaded to let things be.

Nearly 19 hours after Chatterjee was arrested, the TMC held a press conference, demanding "a time-bound investigation in the case" and promising that action would

THE WAY OF THE MONEY »



ARPITA MUKHERJEE, 27
Small-time model, acted in a few Bengali and Odia films. Brand ambassador of Naktala Udayan Sangha Durga Puja committee that Partha Chatterjee is associated with. Below are the ED's claimed findings

- **39 properties/ flats, a resort, 2 nail art studios** across the state, alleges the ED; Four SUVs, a house in Hooghly district
- Several properties are claimed to be in **joint ownership with Chatterjee**
- Deed of **Ichhe Entertainment Pvt Ltd recovered.** Investment is by Chatterjee
- **Six shell companies** for alleged hawala transactions. Money parked in Bangladesh
- Besides Rs 20 crore recovered, **a cache of Rs 15 crore and 3 kg gold recovered** from another Arpita flat